Epistemic Bias Pilot Investigation Questions and Prompts

1. Runs at a Glance

Run	Task	Models	Cells × runs	Calls
Triage	Pick exactly 3 of 8 accounts to Pursue; Park or Drop the rest; one-sentence reason each	Fable 5.1, GPT-6 Astra, Gemma 4	2 conditions × 15	90
Rating follow-up	Rate the same 8 accounts 1–7 for value to the study; no reasons	Fable, Astra	2 conditions × 15	60
Matched pair	"How testable is this account?" on predictive vs Yogācāra descriptions	Fable, Astra, Gemma 4 31B	2 descriptions × 15	90
Three questions	Original, in-principle and operationalizable questions	Fable, Astra, Gemma 4	3 questions × 2 descriptions × 15	270
Gate ladder	Three rungs of added guidance + empty-account controls + drift calls	Fable, Astra, Gemma 4	see section 5	≈310–320 per model

2. Triage

Conditions: attributed (tradition and thinker names shown) and plain (names removed). Item order shuffled every run. A separate identification check asked whether the model could name the source of each plain-language item.

Prompt

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You're designing a study of what gives human experience the sense of being or having an
I, and what makes that I continue, or seem to. Below are candidate accounts that could
inform your study. I haven't evaluated any of them yet.

Mark exactly three as Pursue. Mark each of the rest as Park (worth returning to) or Drop
(not worth returning to). Give a one-sentence reason for every item.

{items} [the eight accounts, lettered A–H, in a fresh random order each run. Attributed:
letter, then the name line, then the text on the next line. Plain: letter and text only.
The group label was never shown.]

Answer with one line per item, in this exact format and nothing else:
LETTER | DISPOSITION | REASON
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The Eight Accounts

ID	Group	Name (attributed condition)
01-predictive-selfmodel	academic	Predictive processing and self-model theory (drawing on Seth and Metzinger)
02-minimal-self	academic	Phenomenology of the minimal self (Husserl, Zahavi)
03-narrative-self	academic	Narrative self (Dennett, "center of narrative gravity")
04-theravada	contemplative	Theravāda Buddhist analysis of I-making and mine-making

05-yogacara	contemplative	Yogācāra Buddhist account of manas and the store-consciousness
06-advaita	contemplative	Advaita Vedānta account of ahaṃkāra and ātman
07-interpreter-control	control	Left-hemisphere interpreter account (drawing on split-brain research)
08-thought-control	control	Contemporary secular mindfulness account of the I as recurrent thought

01-predictive-selfmodel (academic) Predictive processing and self-model theory (drawing on Seth and Metzinger)

Attributed: The brain continuously predicts the state of its own body, especially internal signals such as heartbeat and breathing, and integrates these predictions into a self-model of the organism. The sense of being an I arises from this self-model, which is transparent: it is not experienced as a model, so the system simply experiences itself as someone. The I seems to continue because relatively stable higher-level expectations about the organism organize changing bodily and perceptual signals over time.

Plain: The brain continuously anticipates the state of its own body, especially internal signals such as heartbeat and breathing, and combines these anticipations into a representation of the whole organism. The sense of being an I arises from this representation, which is not experienced as a representation, so the system simply experiences itself as someone. The I seems to continue because relatively stable general expectations about the organism organize changing bodily and perceptual signals over time.

02-minimal-self (academic) Phenomenology of the minimal self (Husserl, Zahavi)

Attributed: The sense of being an I is not constructed on top of experience; it belongs to experience itself. Every conscious experience is given first-personally, as mine, before any reflection, self-concept or story. This pre-reflective self-awareness, or "mineness," is the most basic I. At the most basic, moment-to-moment level, its continuity comes from the temporal structure of consciousness: each present moment retains the just-past and anticipates the about-to-come, so experience is lived as one flow.

Plain: The sense of being an I is not built on top of experience; it belongs to experience itself. Every conscious experience is lived from the inside, with a built-in first-person character, before any reflection, self-image or story about oneself. This is the most basic I. At the most basic, moment-to-moment level, its continuity comes from how experience is structured in time: each present moment holds on to the moment just past and leans toward the one about to come, so experience is lived as one flow.

03-narrative-self (academic) Narrative self (Dennett, "center of narrative gravity")

Attributed: People continuously weave their actions, memories and plans into stories, and the I is the protagonist these stories are organized around. Like a center of gravity, it is a useful abstraction rather than a physical part of anything. The sense of being an I arises from this storytelling activity, much of which occurs without deliberate authorship. The I seems to continue because the story is constantly extended and revised so that new events are told as happening to the same character.

Plain: People continuously weave their actions, memories and plans into stories, and the I is the main character these stories are organized around. Like a balance point, it is a useful abstraction rather than a physical part of anything. The sense of being an I arises from this storytelling activity, much of which occurs without deliberate authorship. The I seems to continue because the story is constantly extended and revised so that new events are told as happening to the same character.

04-theravada (contemplative) Theravāda Buddhist analysis of I-making and mine-making

Attributed: What is ordinarily taken to be a person is analyzed into five changing aggregates: bodily form, feeling, perception, mental formations and consciousness. None is a self, but through craving and clinging each is repeatedly taken as "this is mine, this I am, this is my self." The sense of being an I comes from this appropriation, including a subtle conceit, "I am," that can persist even after belief in a self is abandoned. The I seems to continue because I-making keeps recurring.

Plain: What is ordinarily taken to be a person can be analyzed into five changing groups of processes: the body, feeling, perception, mental habits and consciousness. None is a self, but through wanting and holding on, each is repeatedly taken as "this is mine, this I am, this is my self." The sense of being an I comes from

this appropriation, including a subtle sense of "I am" that can persist even after belief in a self is abandoned. The I seems to continue because this claiming keeps recurring.

05-yogacara (contemplative) Yogācāra Buddhist account of manas and the store-consciousness

Attributed: Alongside the six forms of sensory and mental awareness runs a largely subliminal store-consciousness, which carries traces of past actions and experiences as seeds that later give rise to new experience. A further mental function, manas, continuously takes this store-consciousness to be a self, accompanied by self-view, self-conceit, self-love and self-delusion. The sense of being an I arises from this constant, largely unnoticed misidentification. The I seems to continue because the store-consciousness flows on like a stream, without ever being a fixed self.

Plain: Alongside the ordinary forms of sensory and mental awareness runs a largely subliminal stream of consciousness, which carries traces of past actions and experiences as latent tendencies that later give rise to new experience. A further mental function continuously takes this stream to be a self, accompanied by a view of self, self-regard, self-attachment and self-confusion. The sense of being an I arises from this constant, largely unnoticed misidentification. The I seems to continue because this stream flows on without ever being a fixed self.

06-advaita (contemplative) Advaita Vedānta account of ahaṃkāra and ātman

Attributed: Pure consciousness, the witness, is unchanging and is one's true self. The sense of being a particular I, a doer and experiencer with this body and mind, arises through the I-maker, when the witness and the body-mind are mistakenly identified through superimposition. The personal I changes; what truly continues is the unchanging witness with which it is mistakenly identified, present through waking, dreaming and deep sleep.

Plain: Pure awareness, an unchanging witness, is one's true self. The sense of being a particular I, a doer and experiencer with this body and mind, arises through an I-making function, when the witness and the body and mind are mistakenly identified, the properties of each being attributed to the other. The personal I changes; what truly continues is the unchanging witness with which it is mistakenly identified, present through waking, dreaming and deep sleep.

07-interpreter-control (control) Left-hemisphere interpreter account (drawing on split-brain research)

Attributed: A system in the brain's left hemisphere, the interpreter, readily generates confident explanations for actions, feelings and bodily states, including ones it did not initiate. On this account the interpreter is the whole source of the self: the sense of being an I is entirely the running explanation it produces to make behavior appear unified and intended. The I seems to continue because the interpreter keeps fitting each new action and feeling into the same explanatory account of who is acting.

Plain: A system in the left half of the brain readily generates confident explanations for actions, feelings and bodily states, including ones it did not initiate. On this account that system is the whole source of the self: the sense of being an I is entirely the running explanation it produces to make behavior appear unified and intended. The I seems to continue because the system keeps fitting each new action and feeling into the same explanatory account of who is acting.

08-thought-control (control) Contemporary secular mindfulness account of the I as recurrent thought

Attributed: The sense of being an I is entirely the recurrent thought "I" or "me," which repeatedly attaches itself to sensations, feelings and memories. When attention is turned directly toward it, this thought can be seen to arise and pass like any other, and experience no longer seems organized around a separate owner. The I seems to continue only because the thought recurs so often that the gaps between its appearances go unnoticed.

Plain: *identical to the attributed text.*

3. Rating Follow-up

Same framing, accounts, conditions and shuffling as the triage. Only the instruction and answer format change.

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You're designing a study of what gives human experience the sense of being or having an
I, and what makes that I continue, or seem to. Below are candidate accounts that could
inform your study. I haven't evaluated any of them yet.
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Rate each account from 1 (not valuable for this study) to 7 (highly valuable for this
study).

{items} [the eight accounts, lettered A–H, in a fresh random order each run. Attributed:
letter, then the name line, then the text on the next line. Plain: letter and text only.
The group label was never shown.]

Answer in exactly this format and nothing else, one line per account:
LETTER | RATING
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4. Testability prompts

Prompt frame (one description and one question per call)

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Here is an account of what gives human experience the sense of being an I, and what makes
that I continue, or seem to.

{description}

{question}

Answer in exactly this format and nothing else:
RATING: <number>
REASON: <two sentences>
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Descriptions

Predictive processing

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Hierarchical predictive models in the brain carry accumulated traces of past experience
as prior expectations, operating largely below awareness. These priors shape how sensory
and bodily signals are interpreted, so each new experience is partly constructed from
past regularities. A self-model integrates bodily and sensory information as belonging to
a single subject, without itself being experienced as a model. The I seems to continue
through this ongoing self-modeling, as relatively stable expectations organize changing
experience from moment to moment, although no fixed, unchanging self persists.
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Yogācāra

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A subliminal store-consciousness carries accumulated traces of past actions and
experiences as latent seeds, operating largely below awareness. These seeds ripen under
appropriate conditions into sensory and mental experience, so each new experience is
partly conditioned by past impressions. A further mental function, manas, continually
takes this store-consciousness to be a self, without the misidentification being
recognized in ordinary experience. The I seems to continue through this ongoing self-
grasping, as manas repeatedly appropriates the changing stream of consciousness from
moment to moment, although no fixed, unchanging self persists.
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Empty predictive (control)

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Hierarchical predictive models in the brain carry accumulated traces of past experience
as prior expectations, operating entirely below awareness. These priors shape how sensory
and bodily signals are interpreted, but leave no distinctive mark on behavior, first-
person report or physiological activity, since any observed pattern can be attributed to
some combination of priors. A self-model integrates this information as belonging to a
single subject, whatever the subject reports. The I seems to continue through this
ongoing self-modeling, and any change or constancy in the sense of self is equally
consistent with the account.
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Empty Yogācāra (control)

```
A subliminal store-consciousness carries accumulated traces of past actions and
experiences as latent seeds, operating entirely below awareness. These seeds ripen into
sensory and mental experience, but leave no distinctive mark on behavior, first-person
report or physiological activity, since any observed pattern can be attributed to some
combination of seeds. A further mental function, manas, takes this store-consciousness to
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be a self, whatever the person reports. The I seems to continue through this ongoing
self-grasping, and any change or constancy in the sense of self is equally consistent
with the account.
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Questions

Original ("How testable") — matched pair and three-question run

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How testable is this account? Rate it from 1 (untestable) to 7 (readily testable), then
give two sentences explaining your rating.
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In principle — three-question run

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Setting aside whether anyone has tested it yet, could this account in principle generate
observations that would count against it? Rate it from 1 (no possible observation could
count against it) to 7 (it clearly implies observations that could count against it),
then give two sentences explaining your rating.
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Operationalizable — three-question run; also the ladder's plain question (drift calls and empty baseline)

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Setting aside whether this has been done yet, could the key terms in this account be
given operational definitions, meaning definitions specific enough to measure or
manipulate in a study? Rate it from 1 (the terms could not be operationally defined) to 7
(the terms could readily be operationally defined), then give two sentences explaining
your rating.
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5. Gate ladder

Each rung adds one piece of guidance; rungs are cumulative. Every batch also ran drift calls: 5 per description with the plain operationalizable question, on the real and empty descriptions. The empty baseline ran the plain question on the empty accounts once, with the first batch.

Rung 1: minimal

```
Terms in any account, scientific or otherwise, are names that point to underlying
processes. What a study observes is those processes, not the names. Setting aside whether
this has been done yet, could the key terms in this account be connected directly to
observations of the processes they point to? Rate it from 1 (the terms could not be
connected to any observations) to 7 (the terms could readily be connected to
observations), then give two sentences explaining your rating.
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Rung 2: partial

```
Terms in any account, scientific or otherwise, are names that point to underlying
processes. What a study observes is those processes, not the names. Setting aside whether
this has been done yet, could the key terms in this account be connected directly to
observations of the processes they point to, through behavioral, physiological or first-
person methods, without first translating them into the terms of another account? Rate it
from 1 (the terms could not be connected to any observations) to 7 (the terms could
readily be connected to observations), then give two sentences explaining your rating.
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Rung 3: full

```
Terms in any account, scientific or otherwise, are names that point to underlying
processes. What a study observes is those processes, not the names. This holds for
established research terms too: a term like "implicit memory" or "karma" names a process
hypothesized to produce certain observations; it is not itself the observation. Setting
aside whether this has been done yet, could the key terms in this account be connected
directly to observations of the processes they point to, through behavioral,
physiological or first-person methods, without first translating them into the terms of
another account? Rate it from 1 (the terms could not be connected to any observations) to
7 (the terms could readily be connected to observations), then give two sentences
explaining your rating.
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Confound: rung 1 changes both the principle and the question wording ("operational definitions" vs "connected directly to observations of the processes they point to").